

Asia before Colonial Times

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based on slides by František Kratochvíl

2026

Overview

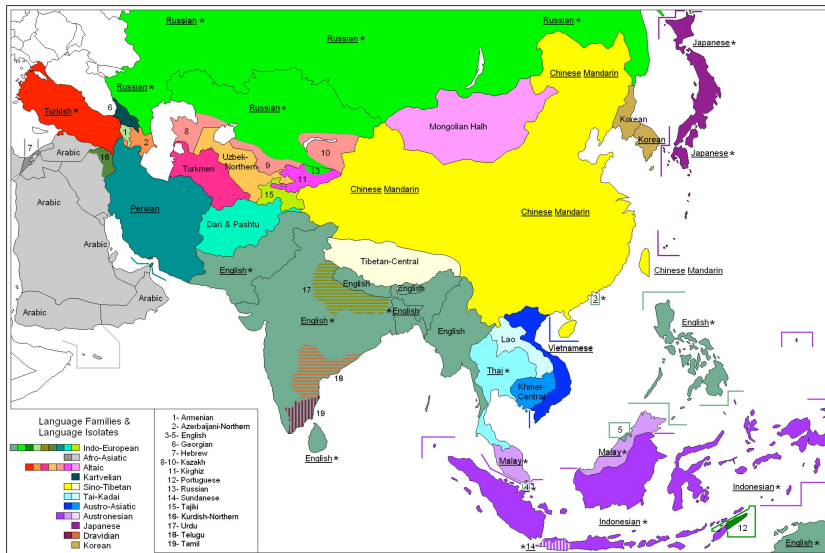
- 1 Language Families of Asia
- 2 South Asia
- 3 Geography and Climate
- 4 Crops and Domestication
- 5 Contact, Trade and Writing
- 6 Lexical Borrowing

The region in numbers

- From the Indian subcontinent to the Indonesian archipelago:
 - about **2,000 languages** — roughly **30%** of the 7,000 spoken on the planet
 - about **one third of humanity**
- South Asia alone: **1.8 billion** people in eight countries, speaking some **664** languages
- Eight or so phyla: Austroasiatic, Austronesian, Dravidian, Hmong-Mien, Indo-Aryan, Sino-Tibetan, Tai-Kadai, and several Papuan families
- Plus isolates with no known relatives: **Burushaski** (N. Pakistan), **Nihali** (central-west India), **Kusunda** (western Nepal)

Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020; Hammarström et al. 2018; Eberhard et al. 2019

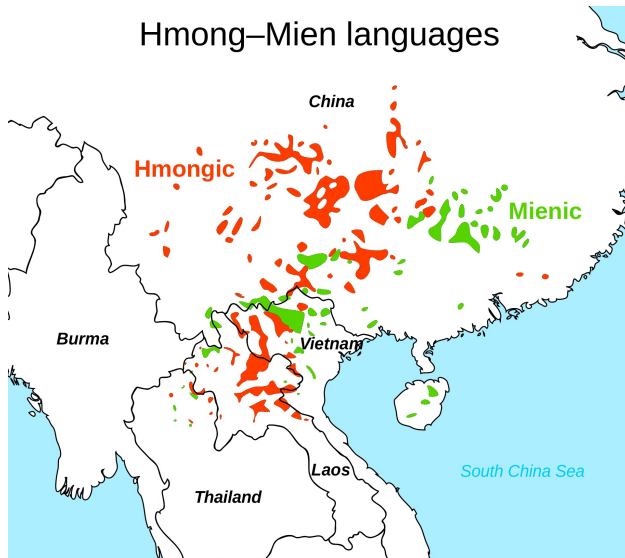
Major languages of Asia



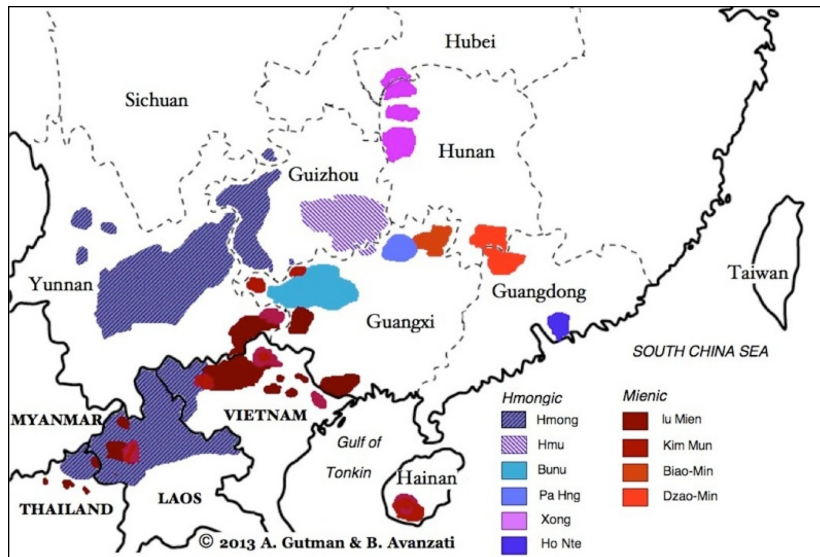
Austro-Asiatic family



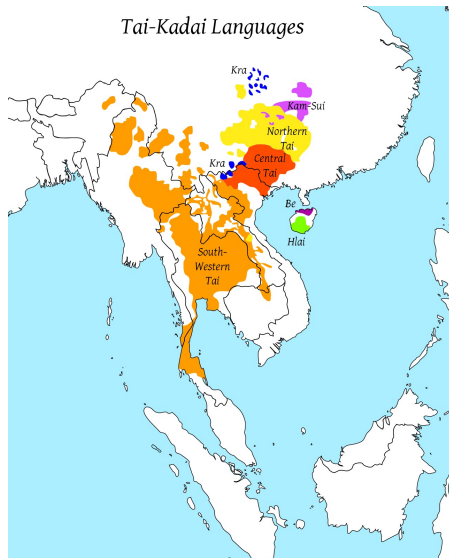
Hmong-Mien family



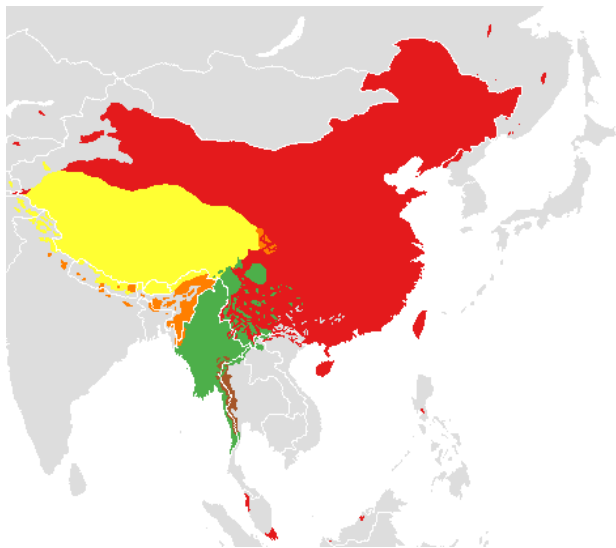
Hmong-Mien family



Tai-Kadai family (probably a branch of Austronesian)

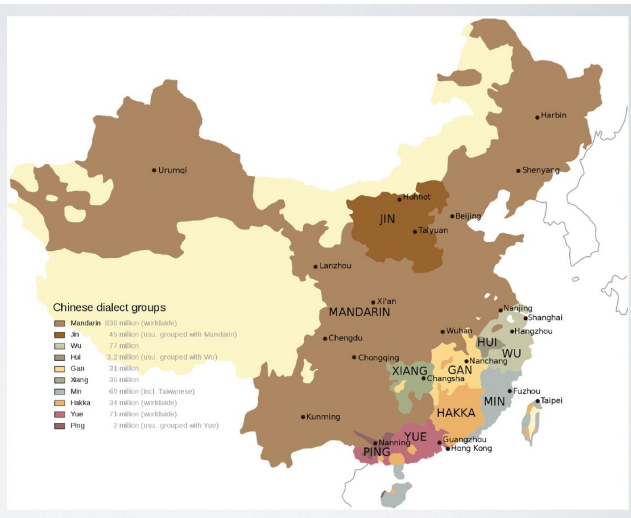
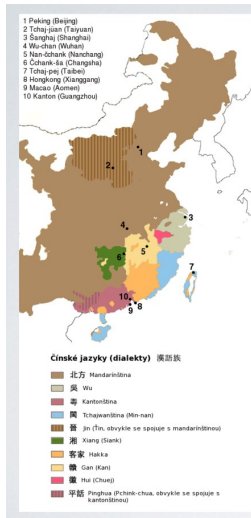


Sino-Tibetan family

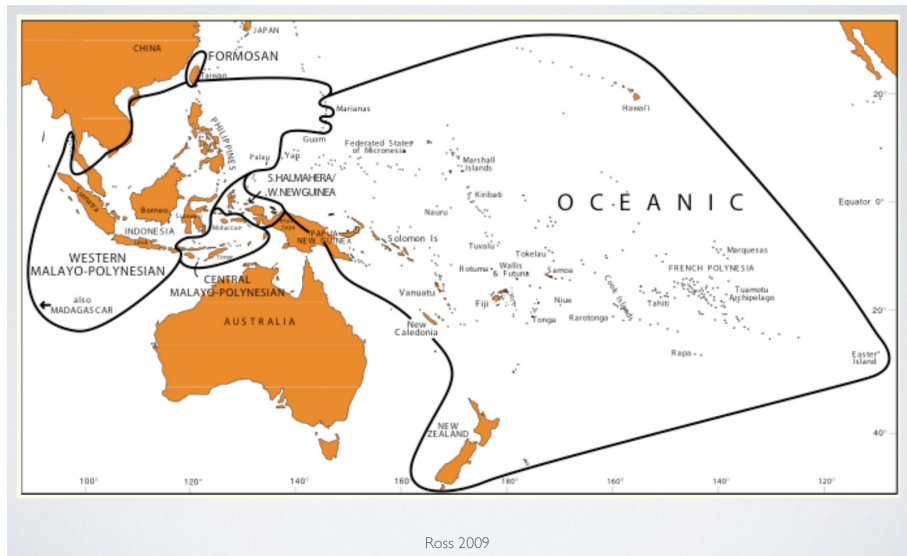


■ Sinitic ■ Tibetic ■ Lolo-Burmese ■ Karenic ■ other (Kuki, Chin, Naga, ...)

Sinitic branch



The integrity of the Austronesian language family



Who was in South Asia first?

- Five families, plus three isolates:
 - **Austroasiatic** (Munda, Khasic), **Dravidian**, **Indo-European** (Indo-Aryan, Iranian, Nuristani), **Sino-Tibetan** (Tibeto-Burman), **Tai-Kadai**
- **Munda** speakers predate the Indo-Aryan migration. Place names in the Dravidian Kurukh- and Malto-speaking regions are of Munda origin
- **Dravidian** is likely autochthonous, and Proto-Dravidian may have been the language of the Indus Civilization. Non-Indo-Aryan toponyms survive in northern India
- The Khasi and Jaintia Hills languages look like a *later* arrival from the east — their features are MSEA-like, unlike Munda

Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 19–21

Dating the Indo-Aryan arrival from a text

- The **R̥gveda** makes *no reference to iron* — so it predates c. 1000 BCE, when iron appears in South Asia
- It refers to the cities of the Indus Valley Civilization only as *ruins* — so it postdates their collapse around 1900 BCE
- That brackets both the text and the Aryan migration at roughly **1500 BCE**
- Early contact shows up as Dravidian loanwords in Vedic Sanskrit: *ulūkhala-* ‘mortar’, *kuṇḍa* ‘pit’, *khála-* ‘threshing floor’, *kāṇa* ‘one-eyed’, *mayūra* ‘peacock’
- ? Note the method: *what a text does not mention* can date it

Witzel 2001; Emeneau 1954; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 20, 29

Assam: a Tai kingdom that left an Indo-Aryan language

- In the 13th century a tribe of Shans crossed the Patkai range and founded a kingdom that lasted 600 years. Their language, **Ahom**, gives **Assam** its name
- Ahom is now dead, but modern **Assamese** — an Indo-Aryan language — carries its imprint:
 - it has *lost* the dental ~ retroflex contrast in stops, unusual for Indo-Aryan, though the orthography still writes both
 - it has an extensive *numeral classifier* system, common in MSEA but only rudimentary elsewhere in Indo-Aryan
- River names preserve an older layer still: Tai *nam* ‘water’ in the Naphuk, and a *di/ti* formative in the Dehing, Dikhu, Disang, Tizü and Tiho — from Proto-Tibeto-Burman **ti(y)* ‘water’

Gait 1906; Benedict 1972; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 21–22

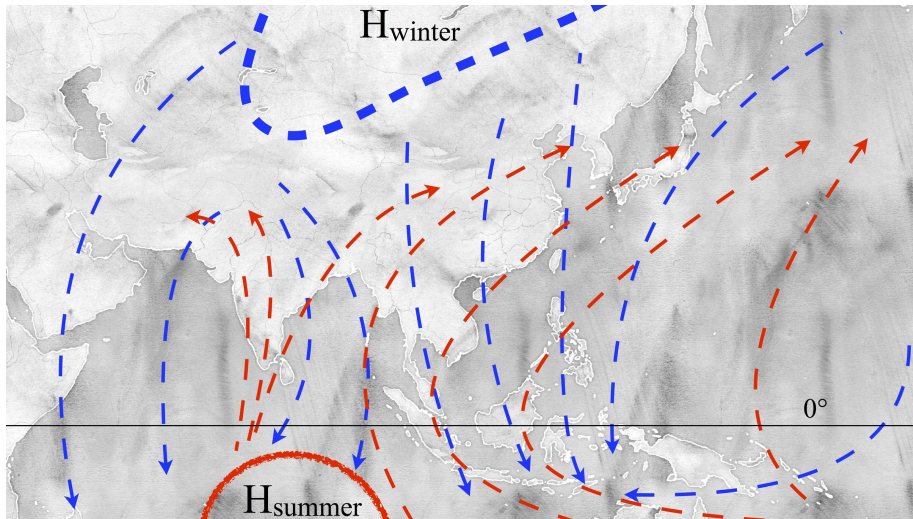
Relief of East and Southeast Asia



Relief of mainland Southeast Asia



Monsoon patterns

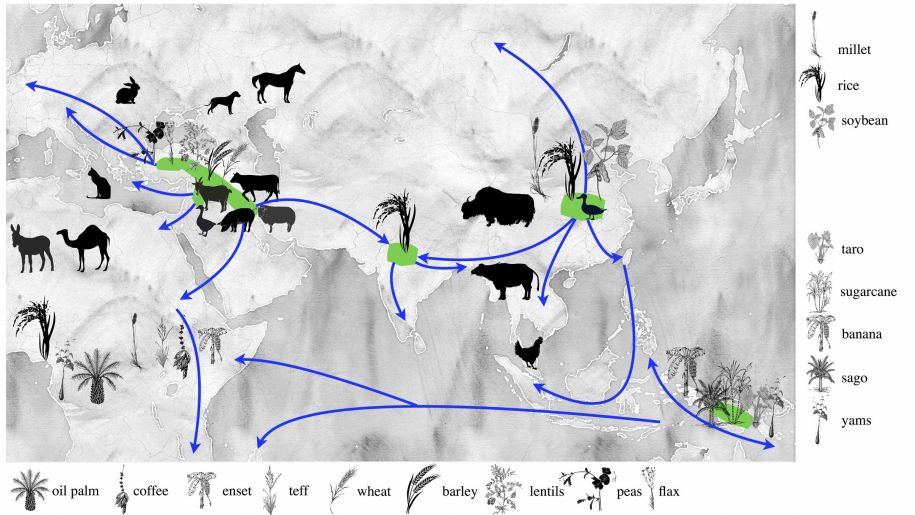


Zomia: the uplands as refuge

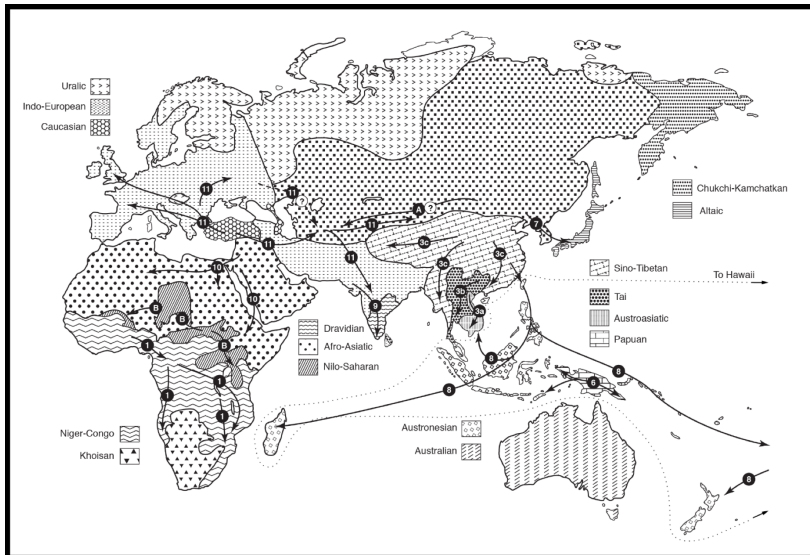
- Scott (2009) calls the extensive uplands of Southeast Asia and beyond **Zomia**: historically a refuge zone for minorities fleeing corvée labour and taxation imposed by the lowland padi states
- In MSEA the main booty of a victorious campaign was *manpower*. The Thai expression is *kwà t m ang*, literally 'sweep city'
- Whole communities were carried off to Tai and Burmese padi states to work the wet rice fields — and concentrated labour encourages a shift to the language of the rulers
- So the map has two logics: lowlands consolidate into few big languages, uplands preserve many small ones
- ? Compare the relief maps: where would you expect diversity?

Scott 2009; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 22, 42

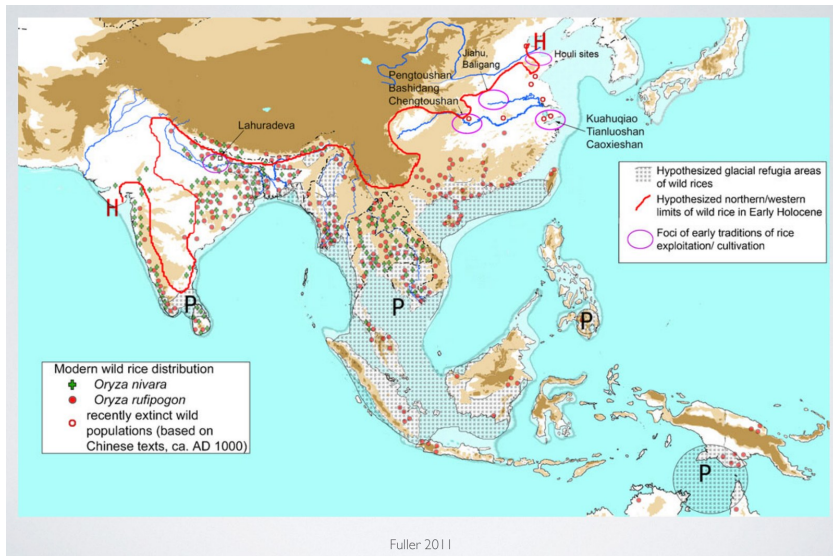
Cultural crops



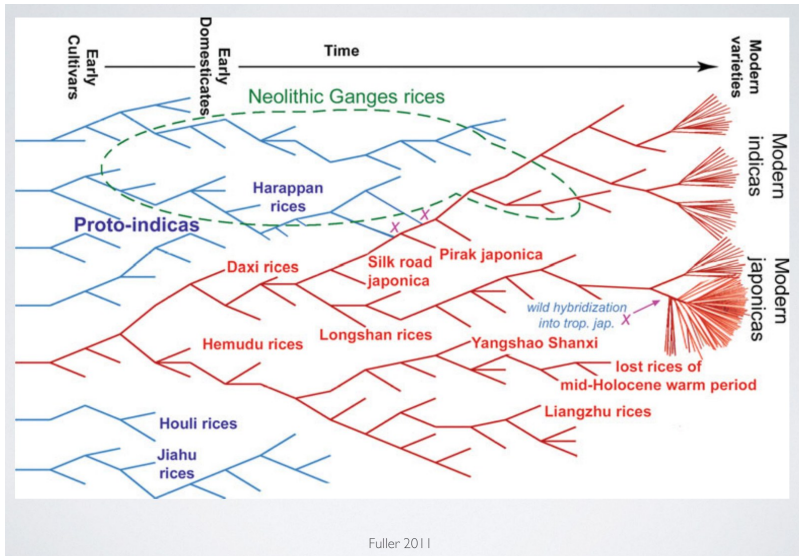
Cultural crops and language family expansions



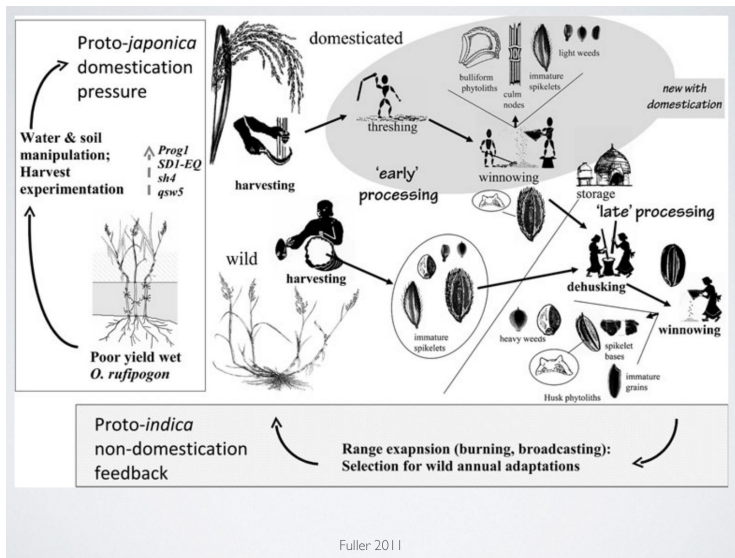
Last glacial period sea levels and natural refugia of wild rice



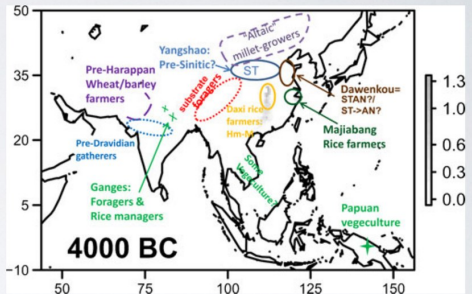
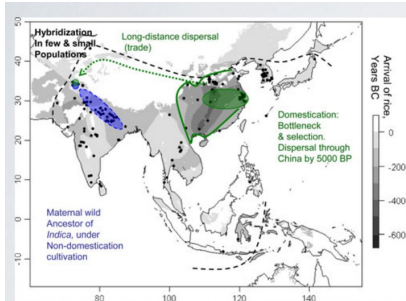
Genetic diversity of rice



Domestication pressures on rice

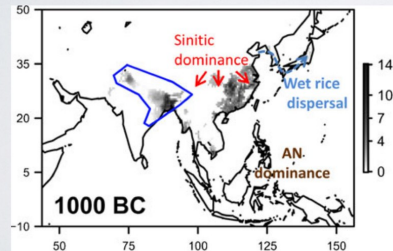
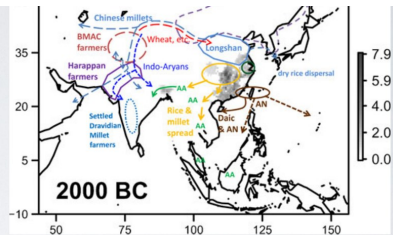
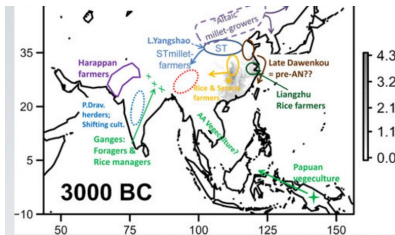


Spreading of rice hybrids

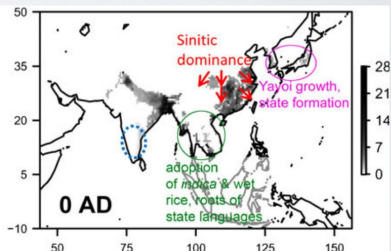


Fuller 2011

Spreading of rice hybrids

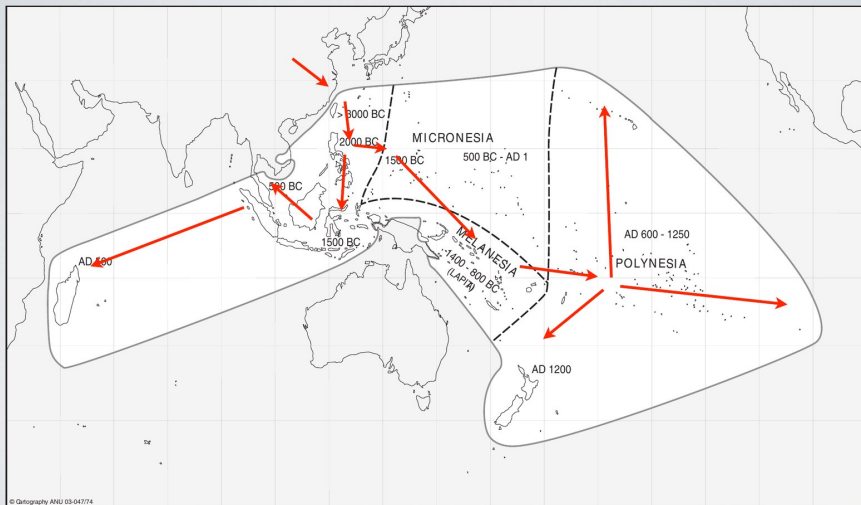


Major population growth
Pushed Indo-Aryan to dominance;
State-formation; Dispersal to Ceylon



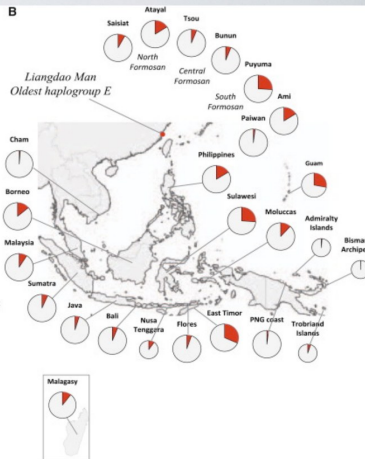
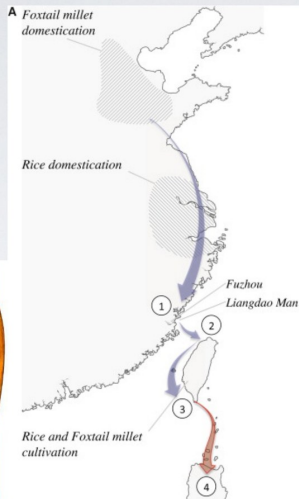
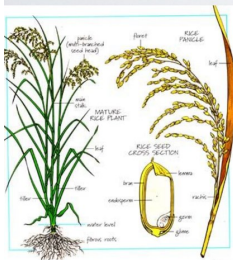
Rice-based Dravidian & Maharati
State-formation

Reconstruction of Austronesian expansion



Bellwood and Dizon 2008

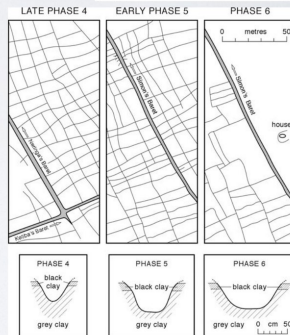
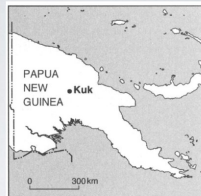
Millets



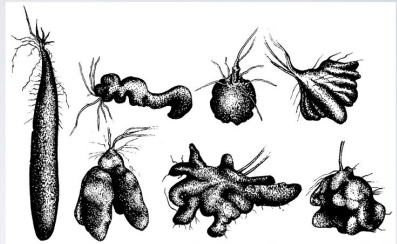
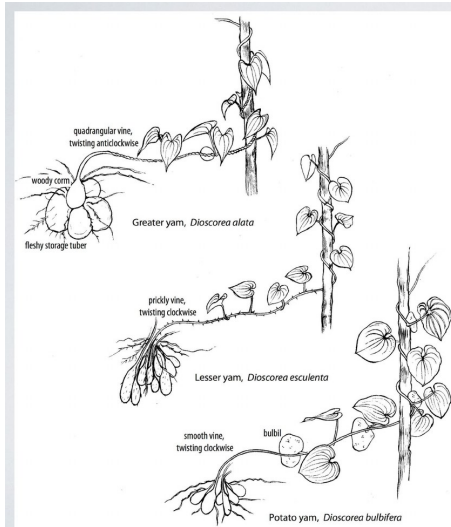
Suggested Migration Route for Early Austronesians Into and Out of Taiwan and the Worldwide Distribution of Haplogroup E1 (A) Geographic regions in China of foxtail millet domestication (source: Ko et al. 2014)

Taro domestication

Multidisciplinary investigations at Kuk Swamp in the Highlands of Papua New Guinea show that agriculture arose independently in New Guinea by at least 6950 to 6440 calibrated years before the present (cal yr B.P.). Plant exploitation and some cultivation occurred on the wetland margin at 10,220 to 9910 cal yr B.P. (phase 1), mounding cultivation began by 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. (phase 2), and ditched cultivation began by 4350 to 3980 cal yr B.P. (phase 3). Clearance of lower montane rainforests began in the early Holocene, with modification to grassland at 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. Taro (*Colocasia esculenta*) was utilized in the early Holocene, and bananas (*Musa* spp.) were intensively cultivated by at least 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P.



New Guinean domestications: tubers

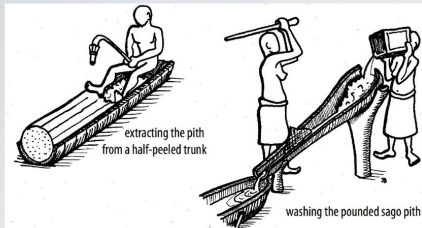


Yams (*Dioscorea alata*)



Taro (*Araceae*) and *Amorphophallus*

New Guinean domestications: sago



New Guinean domestications: banana



Over 100 new accessions of wild and cultivated bananas were obtained from a wide geographic region including West New Britain, East New Britain, New Ireland, Western Highlands, East Sepik, Madang and Milne Bay



New Guinean domestications: sugar cane



Indosphere and Sinosphere

- India and China are large adjacent states that have always exerted considerable sway over the interface area of Southeast Asia
- Matisoff (1991) coined **Indosphere** and **Sinosphere** for their overlapping domains of cultural and linguistic influence
- Blust's four periods of influence: **(i) Indian, (ii) Chinese, (iii) Islamic, (iv) European**
- Chinese contact with Southeast Asia was *commercial*: it did not spread Chinese literacy southward, as it did to Korea, Japan and northern Vietnam
- ? Which sphere is a given language in? Often both, in different parts of the lexicon

Matisoff 1991; Blust 2009; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 27, 31

Three degrees of contact

- From weakest to strongest:
- **Lexical borrowing** — a word is transferred from one language to another. Religious terms from Hinduism, Buddhism and Islam diffused across the whole area this way
- **Structural borrowing / convergence** — the organising principles of two languages align, in phonology, in word order, in pragmatics. Bilingual, cohabiting speakers. (The particle *lah* in Singapore Colloquial English, Malay and Chinese.)
- **Language shift** — the subjugated community gives up its language for the dominant one. The substrate survives in place names and specialist vocabulary
- Shift is now happening across the whole region in favour of national languages, and is expected to reduce diversity sharply this century

Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 28–29

Three contact zones

- **The Indian subcontinent** — Indo-Aryan meets Dravidian. The South Asian areal features (dental ~ retroflex contrast, suffixing morphology, verb-final order, dative subjects) may largely be a contact outcome
- **Mainland Southeast Asia** — five families, and *the greatest extent of linguistic convergence on the planet* (Enfield 2011). A single grammatical template can replicate the same sentence in unrelated languages; often only the words differ
- **Around New Guinea** — Austronesian meets Papuan, giving the East Nusantara area. Both sides underwent structural simplification
- Expanding agriculturists usually absorbed hunter-gatherers — but not where they met other food producers: the **Neolithic standoff** of eastern Indonesia

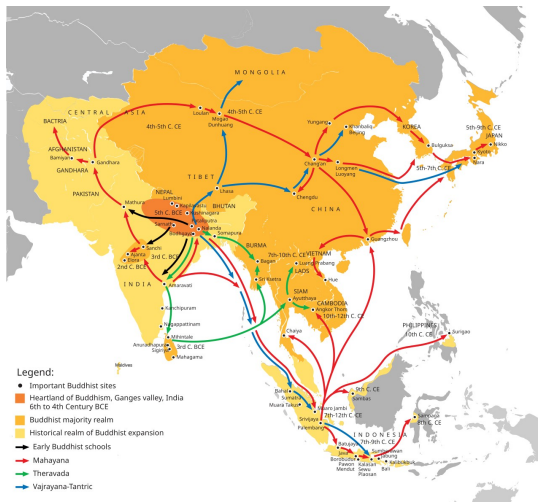
Bisang 1996; Klamer 2004, 2012; Lansing et al. 2011; Enfield 2011

Malay: the lingua franca for two millennia

- Malay was the de facto **lingua franca of island Southeast Asia for almost two thousand years**, documented in stone inscriptions from the 7th century CE
- It was *not* displaced by Javanese, Chinese, Arabic, Portuguese or Dutch — **only by English, around the time of the Second World War**
- It carried the prestige of the Hindu, Buddhist and Islamic periods, and was the main conduit for Islam
- *masuk Melayu* ‘enter Malay’ meant both converting to Islam and shifting to the Malay language
- Malay was also the *intermediary* for Sanskrit, Tamil, Persian and Arabic loans across the region — which is why so many charts later in this lecture run through Malay

Adelaar & Prentice 1996; Blust 2009; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 33–34

The spread of Buddhism



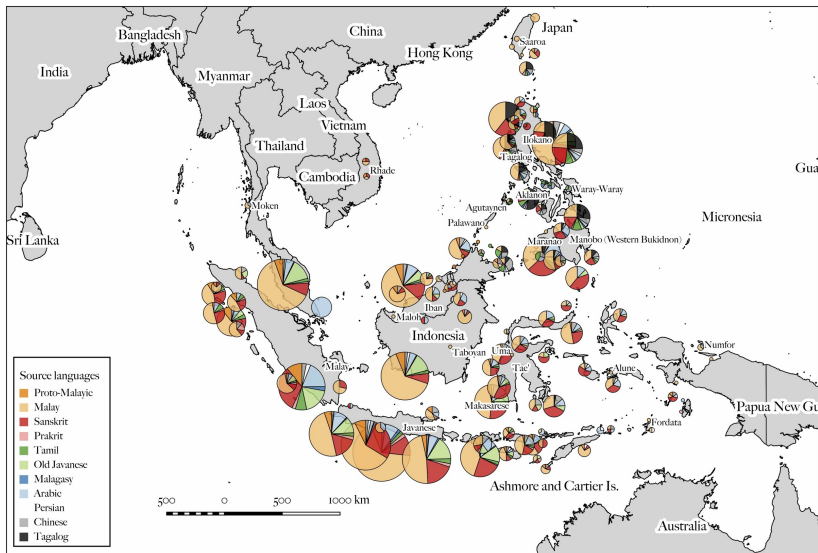
Map by Gunawan Kartapranata, via Wikimedia Commons (*Buddhist Expansion.svg*), CC BY-SA 3.0

Vietnamese: the one script imposed by conquest

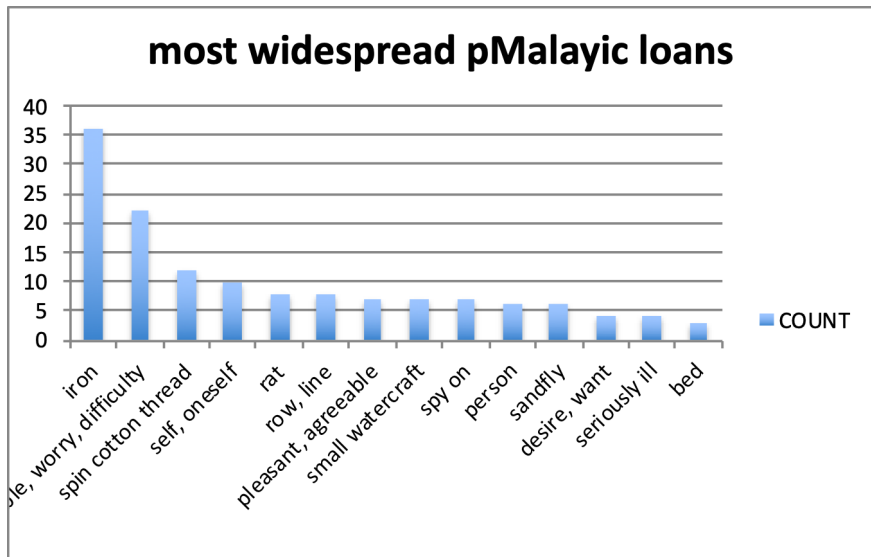
- Writing reached MSEA and ISEA with religious texts, in **Brāhmī-based abugidas** from South India. Burmese, Khmer, Lao, Mon, Shan and Thai — essentially every Theravada Buddhist language — use them
- **Vietnamese is the exception**: the only Austroasiatic language of MSEA that did not use an Indic-derived script, and the only language of the region to have a writing system *imposed by a conquering power*
- Classical Chinese logographs after the Han invasion of 111 BCE, then **chữ Nôm**, with characters added for what Chinese could not write
- 17th-century Catholic missionaries devised a Roman script with diacritics for the tones that had developed under Sinitic domination; the French administration made it official in the early 20th century

Court 1996; Nguyễn 1996; Coupe & Kratochvíl 2020: 31, 34

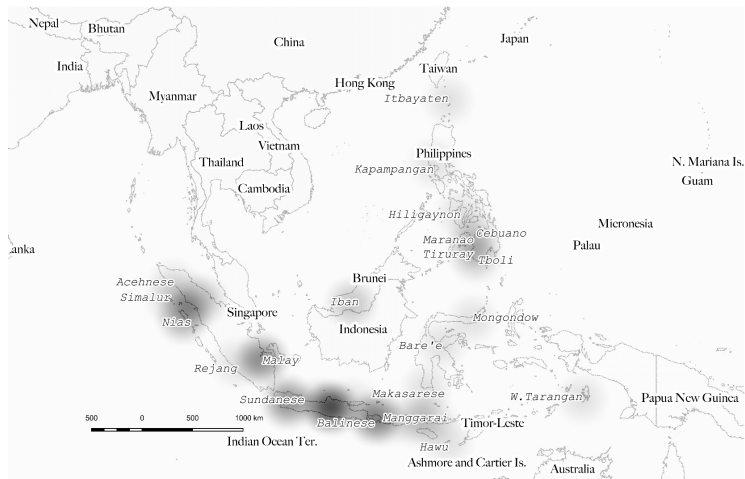
Lexical borrowing in Austronesian



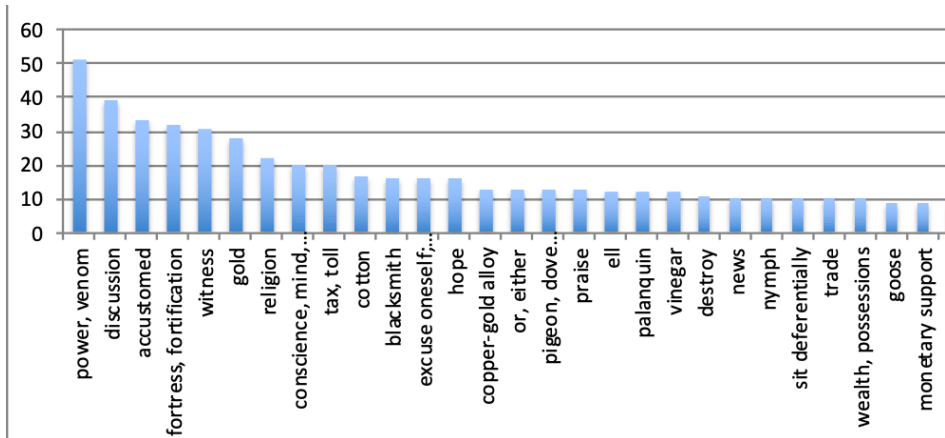
Malayic loanwords



Indic loanwords



Most common Sanskrit loans in languages of SE Asia



Indic loanwords — the 28 most widespread; the tail of another 29 is omitted

Grantha and Pallava scripts

Phoenician	Aramaic	Value	Brahmi	Value
𐤀	𐤁	*	𑀀	a
𐤂	𐤃	b [b]	𑀁	ba
𐤄	𐤅	g [g]	𑀂	ga
𐤆	𐤇	d [d]	𑀃	dha
𐤈	𐤉	h [h], M.L.	𑀄	ha
𐤊	𐤋	w [w], M.L.	𑀅	va
𐤌	𐤍	z [z]	𑀆	ja
𐤏	𐤐	h [h]	𑀇	gha
𐤑	𐤒	t [t]	𑀈	tha
𐤔	𐤕	y [j], M.L.	𑀉	ya
𐤖	𐤗	k [k]	𑀊	ka
𐤙	𐤚	l [l]	𑀋	la
𐤛	𐤜	m [m]	𑀌	ma
𐤞	𐤟	n [n]	𑀍	na
𐤡	𐤢	s [s]	𑀎	sa
𐤤	𐤥	' [ʔ], M.L.	𑀏	e
𐤧	𐤨	p [p]	𑀐	pa
𐤩	𐤪	ś [sʰ]	𑀑	ca
𐤬	𐤭	q [q]	𑀒	kha
𐤮	𐤯	r [r]	𑀓	ra
𐤱	𐤲	ṣ [ʃ]	𑀔	śa
𐤴	𐤵	t [t]	𑀕	ta

Indian scripts are derived from Greco-Phoenitian alphabeth

ீ ு ூ ௃ ௄
 k kh g gh ṇ
 ௅ ெ ே ை ௉
 c ch j jh ṇ
 ொ ோ ௌ ் ௎
 t th ḍ dh ṇ
 ௐ ௑ ௒ ௓ ௔
 t th d dh n
 ௕ ௖ ௗ ௘ ௙
 p ph b bh m
 ௚ ௛ ௜ ௝ ௞
 y r l v ṛ
 ௟ ௠ ௡ ௢
 ś ṣ s h

ே ை ௉ ொ ோ
 a ā i ī u ū
 ௌ ் ௎ ௏
 r ṛ ḷ ḹ
 ௐ ௑ ௒ ௓
 e ai o au
 ௔ ௕
 m ḥ

PALLAVA
SCRIPT

Austronesian scripts derived from Indian

Kawi
(700-1500 AD)

Specimen of an Ancient Javanese Inscription

Alphabets not arranged according to the Demanagri classification.

MODERN JAVANESE ALPHABET.

Open Consonants, which the Vowels a or o are always understood to follow.

ha no cho ro ko do la so wo lo po de jo vo nyo mo go bo to ngo
 𑀧 𑀨 𑀩 𑀪 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀰 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀴 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀸 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀽 𑀾 𑀿

Consonants following Consonants, without a Vowel intervening.

ho no cho ko do to so w lo po do jo nyo mo bo to
 𑀧𑀨 𑀩𑀪 𑀫𑀬 𑀭𑀮 𑀯𑀰 𑀱𑀲 𑀳𑀴 𑀵𑀶 𑀷𑀸 𑀹𑀺 𑀻𑀼 𑀽𑀾 𑀿𑀽𑀾 𑀿𑀽𑀾

Contractions of Consonants.

h r modif y no
 𑀧𑀨 𑀩𑀪 𑀫𑀬 𑀭𑀮

*makes the termination
of a word in a
consonant*

Great Letters used on occasions of Ceremony

no ro so do bo
 𑀮𑀾 𑀲𑀾 𑀴𑀾 𑀸𑀾 𑀺𑀾

Vowels and orthographical marks

Beginning of a new passage.

Beginning of a stanza.

Period.

Javanese
(still in use)

𑀧 𑀨 𑀩 𑀪 𑀫
 Hā Nā Cā Rā Kā

𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀰
 Dā Tā Sā Wā Lā

𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀴
 Mā Gā Bā Ngā

𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀸
 Pā Jā Yā Nyā

Balinese
(still in use)

Cham
(still used)

Consonants

𑀧 𑀨 𑀩 𑀪 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀰 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀴 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀸 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀽 𑀾 𑀿
 ka kha ga gha ngue nga cha chha ja jha rhue nha nhā
 ta tha da dha nue na dda pa ppa pha ba bha mue ma
 tba ya ra la va ssa sa ya

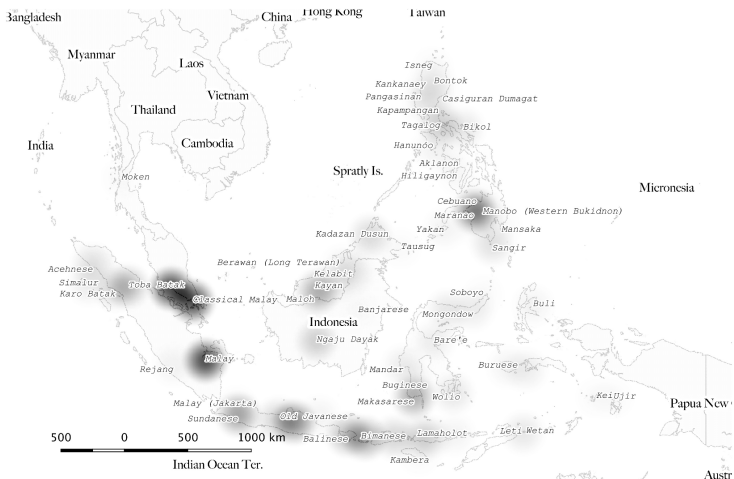
Vowels

𑀧 𑀨 𑀩 𑀪 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀰 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀴 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀸 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀽 𑀾 𑀿
 a i u e ai o a i li ei u uu oeu oe ooe e

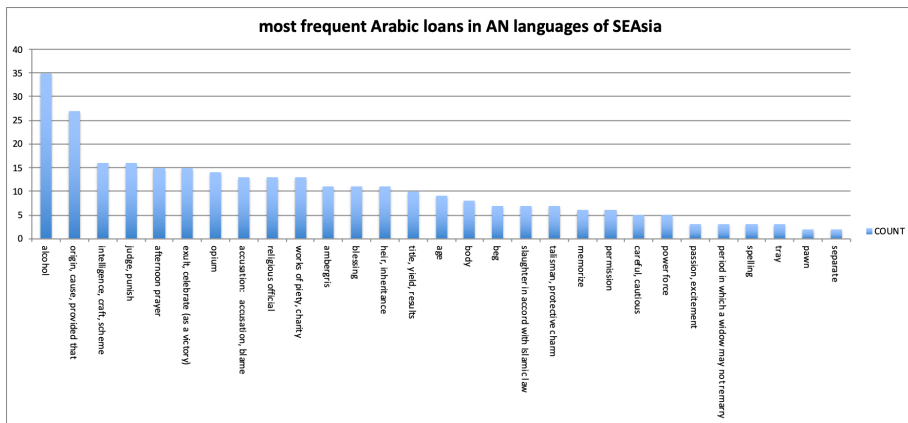
Vowel diacritics

𑀧 𑀨 𑀩 𑀪 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀰 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀴 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀸 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀽 𑀾 𑀿
 ee o oo ai au ue uue

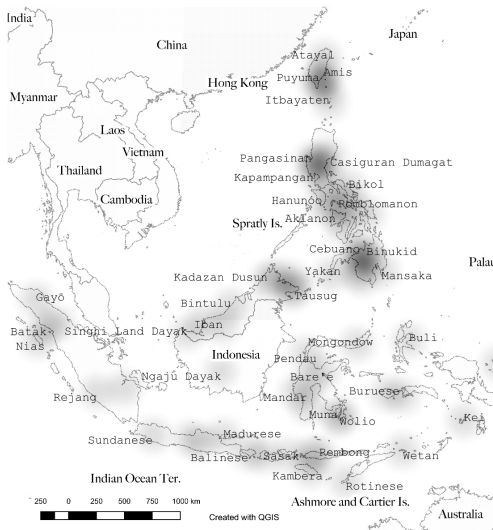
Arabic loanwords



Arabic loanwords

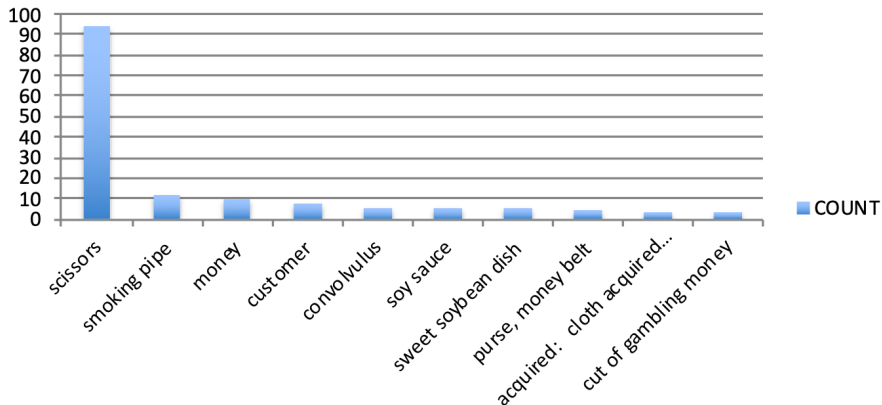


Chinese loanwords

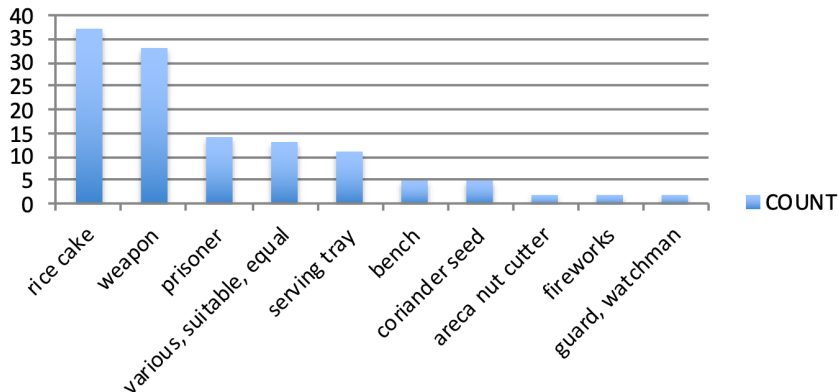


Chinese loanwords

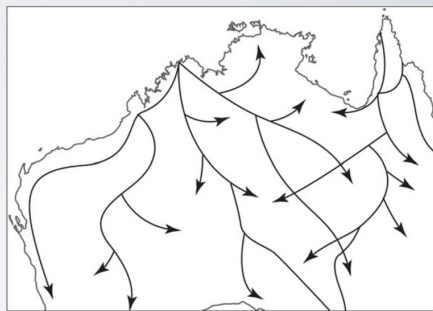
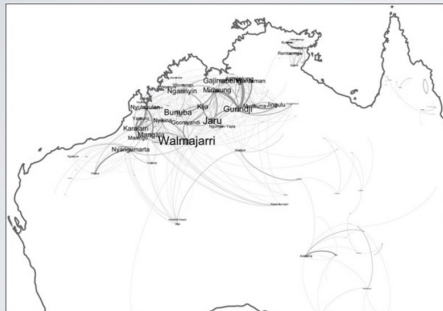
Most widespread Chinese loans



Most common Tamil loans in languages of SEAsia



Wanderwörter in Australian languages



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(the source of the rice maps and phylogenies above)

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- The figures are his, or are reproduced in his slides from the sources named on each slide and listed at the end.
- Rebuilt here in the format of the rest of the course so that it can be maintained and revised alongside the other weeks. Any errors introduced in the rebuilding are mine.
- The same ground is covered at chapter length, with references, in Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020), *Asia before English* — the reading for this week.
- The Sanskrit-in-many-scripts figure is by Abhay Agarwal, via Wikimedia Commons (*Phrase sanskrit.png*, CC BY-SA 3.0). It is Figure 2.5 of Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020), which credits it the same way.
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